

Team Dynamics & Communication

Software is built by teams. How those teams communicate and work together often matters more than individual technical skill.

What Makes Teams Effective

Effective teams share a few characteristics:

- **Shared understanding** — Everyone knows what they're building and why
- **Trust** — People believe their teammates are competent and have good intentions
- **Psychological safety** — People feel safe to ask questions, admit mistakes, and disagree
- **Clear communication** — Information flows freely; no one is left in the dark

These sound soft, but they directly impact delivery. A team with great communication and average skills will outperform a team with great skills and poor communication.

How Information Flows

In healthy teams, information flows easily. People share what they're working on, what's blocking them, and what they've learned.

In unhealthy teams, information gets stuck:

- **Silos** — Teams or individuals hoard knowledge
- **Bottlenecks** — Everything routes through one person
- **Assumptions** — People think others know things they don't

Most communication problems aren't about tools. They're about habits and trust.

Knowledge Sharing

Code doesn't explain itself. Teams need deliberate practices to share knowledge:

- **Code reviews** — Not just catching bugs, but spreading understanding
- **Pair programming** — Real-time knowledge transfer (covered more in Practices)
- **Documentation** — Writing things down so others (and future you) can understand
- **Conversations** — Sometimes the best documentation is a five-minute chat

The goal is to avoid single points of failure — situations where only one person understands something critical.

Common Dysfunctions

Watch for these patterns:

- **Blame culture** — When something breaks, people look for who to blame instead of what to fix
- **Information hoarding** — Knowledge as power instead of knowledge as shared resource
- **Hero culture** — Celebrating people who work 80-hour weeks to "save" projects
- **Meeting overload** — Substituting meetings for actual communication

Remote and Distributed Teams

Remote work amplifies both good and bad communication patterns.

What helps:

- **Over-communicate** — What's obvious to you isn't obvious to others
- **Write things down** — Async communication needs documentation
- **Be intentional about connection** — Casual hallway conversations don't happen automatically
- **Assume good intent** — Text lacks tone; give people the benefit of the doubt